

## FROM MEDIOCRISTAN TO EXTREMISTAN, AND BACK

*I prefer Horowitz—How to fall from favor—The long tail—Get ready for some surprises—It's not just money*

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Let us see how an increasingly man-made planet can evolve away from mild into wild randomness. First, I describe how we get to Extremistan. Then, I will take a look at its evolution.

### *The World Is Unfair*

Is the world that unfair? I have spent my entire life studying randomness, practicing randomness, hating randomness. The more that time passes, the worse things seem to me, the more scared I get, the more disgusted I am with Mother Nature. The more I think about my subject, the more I see evidence that the world we have in our minds is different from the one playing outside. Every morning the world appears to me more random than it did the day before, and humans seem to be even more fooled by it than they were the previous day. It is becoming unbearable. I find writing these lines painful; I find the world revolting.

Two “soft” scientists propose intuitive models for the development of this inequity: one is a mainstream economist, the other a sociologist. Both simplify a little too much. I will present their ideas because they are easy to understand, not because of the scientific quality of their insights or any consequences in their discoveries; then I will show the story as seen from the vantage point of the natural scientists.

Let me start with the economist Sherwin Rosen. In the early eighties, he wrote papers about “the economics of superstars.” In one of the papers he conveyed his sense of outrage that a basketball player could earn \$1.2 million a year, or a television celebrity could make \$2 million. To get an idea of how this concentration is increasing—i.e., of how we are moving away from Mediocristan—consider that television celebrities and sports stars (even in Europe) get contracts today, only two decades later, worth in the hundreds of millions of dollars! The extreme is about (so far) twenty times higher than it was two decades ago!